CONGRESS / SACHIN PILOT

ON A WING AND A PROTEST

By Rohit Parihar



Sachin Pilot, once seen as Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's chief ministerial choice for Rajasthan, is now the party's leading dissident. On April 11, despite warnings, he sat on a five-hour fast in Jaipur, to protest against Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot's alleged failure to investigate corruption charges against former BJP chief minister Vasundhara Raje.

Pilot went ahead with the fast even as Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, the All India Congress Committee general secretary in-charge of Rajasthan, issued him a written warning on the night of April 10, stating that any such proposed move will be deemed "anti-party activity". The symbolism was conspicuous as Pilot sat on fast with Mahatma Gandhi's photograph in the backdrop. There were no pictures of Sonia Gandhi or Rahul, leaving many wondering if it was Pilot's way to express his disappointment with the high command. Only three years ago, in July 2020, Pilot had suffered the ignominy of perhaps being the only state Congress president ever sacked for attempting to pull down his own party's government. He was removed as the deputy CM too. Ever since, he has been engaged in manoeuvres of both one-upmanship and brinkmanship against Gehlot, without success.

Once again, the former state party chief ignored clear signals from the high command that was rallying behind Gehlot ever since Pilot announced his intentions on April 9. The party is upset that Pilot chose to attack Gehlot on a day when it was discussing the upcoming Karnataka election in Delhi. Jairam Ramesh, the Congress general secretary in-charge of communications, was quick to laud Gehlot's governance model with which the party plans to go to the polls in Rajasthan later this year. Meanwhile, defending Gehlot, party leader Pawan Khera said the CM was not only probing the alleged role of Union minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat (who like Raje is a frontrunner for chief ministership if the BJP comes to power in the state) in the Sanjivani Credit Cooperative Society scam but also his alleged attempt to topple the Rajasthan government in 2020—a clear hint that the probe could extend to Pilot.

DESPITE CONGRESS DIKTAT, PILOT HAS TAKEN ON CM GEHLOT FOR ALLEGED FAILURE TO ACT IN CORRUPTION CASES AGAINST THE FORMER RAJE REGIME

Pilot says that as the Rajasthan Congress chief he had time and again raised the issue of alleged corruption during Raje's tenure, promising a thorough probe ahead of the 2018 election. Gehlot, he alleges, failed to act. Most cases that Pilot lists did well as political rhetoric, but fell flat because of the lack of evidence before the inquiry committees and courts. To many, it seems, he is raking up issues that have lost relevance.

Among them is Pilot's renewed demand for a CBI probe into the alleged mining scam, which was exposed by the Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) during Raje's tenure in 2015. Not only did Raje cancel all mining leases in question, but senior IAS officer Ashok Singhvi was arrested for his alleged role. The Rajasthan High Court had even dismissed a PIL seeking a CBI probe. Pilot's other charges concern a few antique carpets that went missing from the government